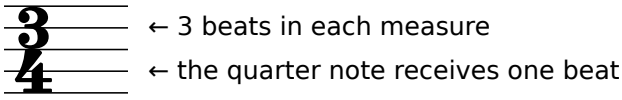
Beat, Meter, and Time Signatures

The beat is the steady pulse of the music, the pulse a listener taps along to. Beats are not all equal. A **strong beat** is a beat that carries more weight; a **weak beat** is a beat that carries less. **Meter** is the grouping of beats into a repeating pattern of strong and weak beats. Each group fills one measure.

Time signatures

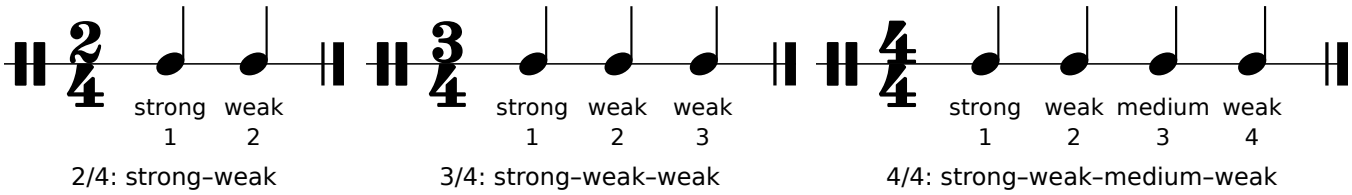
A **time signature** is the pair of numbers at the start of the music that states the meter. It appears after the clef and the key signature, with one number above the other.

- The top number is the number of beats in each measure.
- The bottom number is the note value that receives one beat: 4 means a quarter note, 8 means an eighth note, and 2 means a half note.



Three common meters

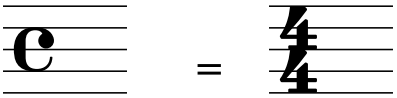
Each meter has its own pattern of strong and weak beats. Beat 1 of every measure is the strongest. In 4/4, beat 3 is a medium beat: stronger than beats 2 and 4, weaker than beat 1.



2/4: strong–weak 3/4: strong–weak–weak 4/4: strong–weak–medium–weak

Common time

Common time is another name for 4/4. It is written with the symbol C in place of the two numbers. The two signatures at the right mean the same thing: four beats in each measure, with the quarter note receiving one beat.



Common time 4/4

Tempo

Tempo is the speed of the beat. A **metronome mark** such as ♩ = 80 at the start of a piece means 80 quarter-note beats per minute. Tempo is also written with Italian words:

Largo	very slow and broad	***Allegro***	fast and lively
Adagio	slow	***Presto***	very fast
Andante	at a walking pace	***ritardando (rit.)***	gradually slower
Moderato	at a moderate speed	***a tempo***	return to the first tempo

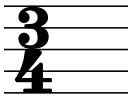
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Name _____ Date _____

Time Signature Meaning

A. Read the time signature Write the number of beats in each measure and the note that receives one beat.

EXAMPLE



Beats 3

Beat note quarter note

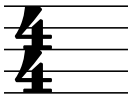
1.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

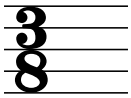
2.



Beats _____

Beat note _____
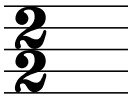
3.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

4.



Beats _____

Beat note _____
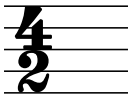
5.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

6.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

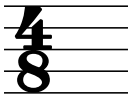
7.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

8.



Beats _____

Beat note _____

B. Write the time signature Write the time signature that matches each description.

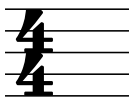
EXAMPLE Three beats; the quarter note receives one beat — **3/4**

1. Two beats; the quarter note receives one beat — ____
2. Four beats; the quarter note receives one beat — ____
3. Two beats; the half note receives one beat — ____
4. Three beats; the eighth note receives one beat — ____
5. Three beats; the half note receives one beat — ____
6. Two beats; the eighth note receives one beat — ____
7. Four beats; the half note receives one beat — ____
8. Four beats; the eighth note receives one beat — ____

C. Match the beat pattern Write the letter of the beat pattern that matches each time signature.

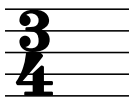
A strong – weak **B** strong – weak – weak **C** strong – weak – medium – weak

EXAMPLE



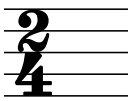
C

1.



_____

2.



_____

3.



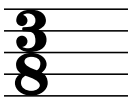
_____

4.
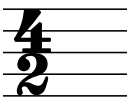


_____

5.



_____

6.



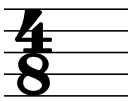
_____

7.



_____

8.



_____

D. Tempo Write the Italian term that matches each description.

EXAMPLE At a walking pace: Andante

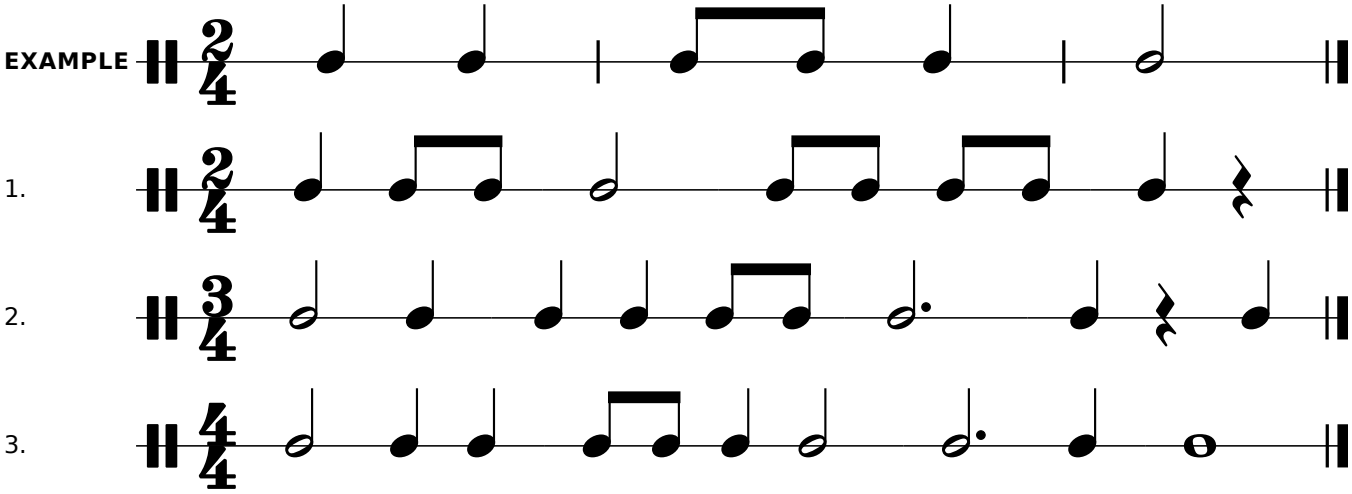
2. Slow: _____
4. Very slow and broad: _____
6. Gradually slower: _____
1. Fast and lively: _____
3. Very fast: _____
5. At a moderate speed: _____
7. Return to the first tempo: _____

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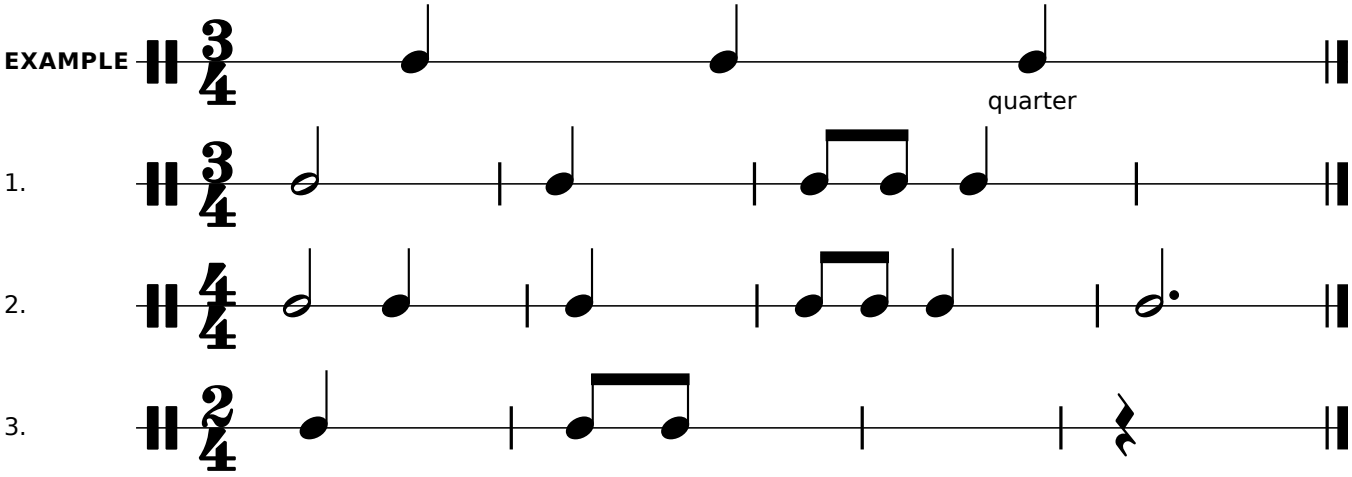
Name _____ Date _____

Bar Lines and Complete Measures

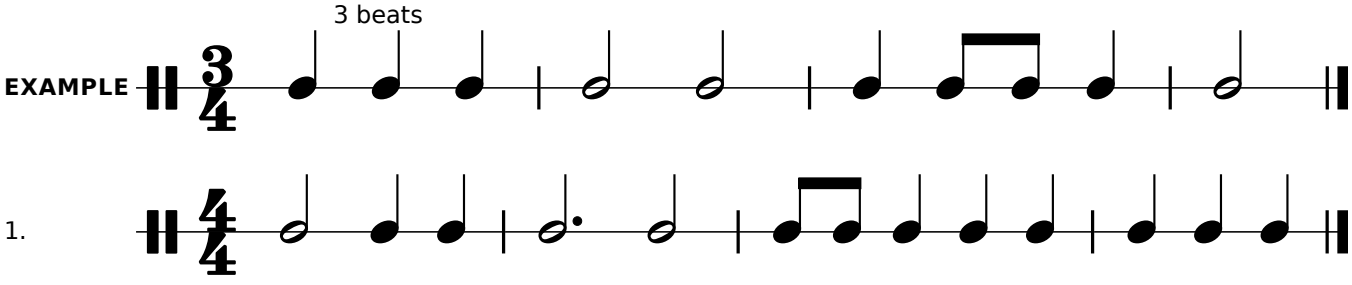
A. Add the bar lines Draw a bar line after each complete measure.



B. Add one note Add one note to the end of each measure to complete it.



C. Find the incorrect measures Write the beat total above each measure, mark each incorrect measure with an X, and correct it.



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